A WORKED EXAMPLE FOR THE JUNIOR CONSULTANT ROLE AT APPDRAFT

From a client call to a test plan.

One Salesforce and Xero billing project, written up the way I would write it: the one page that goes back to the client, the call it came from, the questions only they can answer, the test plan and the handover.

From Hemanth Vallamkonda, applying for the role. vallamkondahemanth@gmail.com

> The client is invented and nothing here is connected to Salesforce or Xero. This is a worked example, not a project I have delivered. I keep a Xero ledger and have worked on invoicing and billing, so I know the finance side of this problem from the inside.

ILLUSTRATIVE Everything in this case file concerns an invented client, Marlowe Row Maintenance.

Marlowe Row Maintenance: your billing, from Salesforce to Xero

What we heard, what we will set up, what you decide.

What we heard

- Owen types every won job into Xero by hand: about six hundred invoices a month, with a pile at month end.
- Planned maintenance is billed monthly in advance, with a price rise each April. Repairs are billed when the job is finished, sometimes with a deposit first.
- Nothing should reach a customer without your finance manager seeing it, and they are away in the last week of every month.
- Customers pay in parts and dispute invoices, the sales team cannot see any of it, and some customers appear twice in Xero. Billing anyone twice would be the worst outcome.

What we will set up

- A draft invoice appears in Xero when a repair is finished or a monthly invoice falls due, with your account code, VAT treatment, Region, the customer's PO number and payment terms already filled in.
- Your finance manager approves every draft in Xero, as now. A named person covers when they are away, and a warning goes out the day before the books close if any invoice is still waiting.
- If an amount changes after an invoice is approved, nothing is billed twice: your finance manager gets a task and decides in Xero.
- Payments, part payments, credit notes and voids show against the job in Salesforce for the sales team, who do not see technical errors.
- Anything unusual, such as a possible double customer, stops and asks. Failures go on a list, with one email each morning only if there were any.

What you decide, and who decides

1. **Where should the monthly billing schedule for a contract live?** We suggest a billing schedule in Salesforce, created when a contract is won. (G-01: your finance manager and us)
2. **What counts as a finished repair, and where is the final amount entered?** We suggest a completion date and a final amount, entered by operations. (G-02: the managing director and your finance manager)
3. **Which day is each monthly invoice dated, and which April is the first price rise?** We suggest each contract's own day, and the first April after the contract starts. (G-17: your finance manager)
4. **Which work is zero rated, exempt or reverse charge?** We suggest standard VAT unless your finance manager says otherwise, and reverse charge held for review. Please check with your accountant. (G-05: your finance manager and the accountant)
5. **Which customers must quote a purchase order, and who receives the invoice?** We suggest a flag on customers who need a PO, a billing contact for managing agents, and invoices held until a needed PO arrives. (G-06: your finance manager)
6. **Which month do you stop typing, and who links the existing customers?** We suggest a month boundary after a rehearsal, with your finance manager deciding each double. (G-09: your finance manager)

13 more questions, each with our suggestion, are in the full list.

How we will check it

Everything is built in a Salesforce sandbox linked to a Xero demo company. You can run 20 of the 26 checks yourselves; we run the other 6 while you watch. We rehearse a month end before anything touches your live Xero.

What it will not do yet

The one customer who pays in euros stays manual. Chasing late payers is a separate conversation.

WHO SENT THIS

What I have done that this draws on

The finance side

I keep a Xero ledger, reconcile the bank, the sales channels and the suppliers, and have supported VAT return preparation for UK clients. I have worked on invoicing and billing, and I administer Salesforce and the CRM in my finance and operations role.

Explaining numbers to owners

I prepared monthly management accounts for 30+ SME client entities and explained each movement in plain commentary that the owners could act on.

Testing with a person in the loop

I built a test-design tool in which a tester approves every case before it reaches a client. It cut test design from a full 8-hour day, or 2 to 3 days on larger projects, to 1 to 3 supervised hours.

ILLUSTRATIVE The call, the questions, the requirements and the checks below concern the same invented client.

TWO

The call

Extract from an illustrative call of about an hour, with the small talk and tangents left in. The client is a fourteen-person UK property maintenance company. Planned maintenance contracts billed monthly in advance; one-off repairs invoiced on completion. Deals in Salesforce Sales Cloud; invoices in Xero; the finance manager re-keys won deals by hand. Open the call, or choose a requirement or a question, to see the lines it came from.

L01	CONSULTANT	Thanks for making the time, and sorry about the screen share dropping earlier. I'd like to understand how a job turns into an invoice, from the very start. Who touches it?
L02	MANAGING DIRECTOR	Right. So a deal gets won in Salesforce, the sales team mark it Closed Won, and then Owen types it all into Xero. We do about six hundred invoices a month, give or take.
L03	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	Give or take is right. Month end is the worst. We get a pile of the planned maintenance ones all at once. We close on the third working day.

L04	CONSULTANT	Tell me about planned maintenance compared with repairs.
L05	MANAGING DIRECTOR	Planned maintenance is a contract. Twelve or twenty four months, billed monthly in advance, the same amount each month. The contract itself is a PDF on the shared drive, and the start date goes in the opportunity notes. Sometimes.
L06	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	Not sometimes. Usually. But then every April we put the price up by whatever the index says, so it's not always the same amount.
L07	MANAGING DIRECTOR	Repairs are one off and we invoice when the job is finished.
L08	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	Although for the big repairs we bill a deposit up front. Half, usually. Not always half.
L09	CONSULTANT	So the invoice goes out when the deal is won?
L10	MANAGING DIRECTOR	Yes. Well, for repairs it's when the job is done, not when it's won. Owen knows.
L11	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	It depends. I check with the engineers. The final amount is often different from the quote, because of parts.
L12	CONSULTANT	What goes on the invoice lines?
L13	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	A description, a quantity and a price. Planned maintenance goes to account two hundred, repairs to two ten. I've to pick the right one every time, and I get it wrong when I'm rushed.
L14	MANAGING DIRECTOR	Can we talk about the vans at some point? The fuel cards are a mess. Sorry. Carry on.
L15	CONSULTANT	And VAT?
L16	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	Most of it's twenty percent. Some new build work is zero rated, and a couple of the housing associations are exempt, I think. And some of the subcontractor work might be reverse charge, I'd need to ask our accountant.
L17	MANAGING DIRECTOR	We just need the right VAT on it. Owen is the expert.
L18	CONSULTANT	Do you split income by anything in Xero?
L19	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	Region. North and South. It's a tracking category. There is a second one for job type, I think, that someone set up years ago. I don't use it.
L20	MANAGING DIRECTOR	I want the regional numbers every month. For the board pack.
L21	CONSULTANT	When the invoice is created, who approves it?

L22	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	Me. I want to look at every one before it goes to the customer. Nothing should go out without me seeing it. Although I'm off the last week of every month at the moment, school run, so someone else would have to.
L23	MANAGING DIRECTOR	Fine, but it shouldn't slow things down. The sync should be quick.
L24	CONSULTANT	What does quick mean to you?
L25	MANAGING DIRECTOR	I don't know. Not days. Before the end of the day, ideally.
L26	CONSULTANT	What do the housing associations need on an invoice?
L27	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	A purchase order number. They send it straight back if it's missing. And the invoice goes to the managing agent, not the landlord, even though the landlord is the customer in Salesforce.
L28	CONSULTANT	And payment terms?
L29	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	Thirty days, mostly. Forty five for the housing associations. Sixty for one of them, they won't move.
L30	CONSULTANT	What happens if the amount changes after the invoice has gone to the customer?
L31	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	It does happen. Sales renegotiate. Honestly I'd just want to know about it, and I'd sort it out in Xero.
L32	MANAGING DIRECTOR	Don't let it create a second invoice. That would be a disaster. Last time it happened with the old tool we had to apologise to a customer.
L33	CONSULTANT	What about customers paying in parts?
L34	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	All the time. Housing associations especially. They pay half, then the rest weeks later. Xero still shows it as awaiting payment, which confuses the sales team. And the payment only shows up once I've matched it to the bank feed, so it can be days.
L35	MANAGING DIRECTOR	The sales team want to see in Salesforce whether a customer is behind before they send a new quote.
L36	CONSULTANT	And credit notes?
L37	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	When there is a dispute. I raise them in Xero. I'd like sales to be able to see them against the job.
L38	CONSULTANT	Does anything get voided?
L39	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	Occasionally, if I made a mistake. I void it and redo it.

L40	CONSULTANT	Do customers ever appear twice in Xero?
L41	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	Yes, unfortunately. The same company with slightly different names, from before my time. About four hundred contacts altogether, and I'd say thirty of them are doubles. I'd rather it stopped and asked me than guessed.
L42	MANAGING DIRECTOR	And one customer pays in euros. One. I don't want to spend money on that.
L43	CONSULTANT	If something fails to go across, how would you want to find out?
L44	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	Not at month end. I want a list I can look at, and an email in the morning if anything failed. The MD does not need to see it.
L45	MANAGING DIRECTOR	I don't care how it works as long as nothing goes missing.
L46	CONSULTANT	What happens at the start? Last year's invoices are all in Xero already.
L47	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	Yes. We would have to pick a month and stop typing them. I'm nervous about doing it twice.
L48	CONSULTANT	How do you chase late payers today?
L49	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	Mondays. I go through the aged debtors report in Xero and email people one by one. It takes most of the morning. I didn't know Xero could send reminders by itself.
L50	MANAGING DIRECTOR	If we could stop doing that by hand, that would be worth something. And the engineers keep asking me for job sheets. That's a separate headache.
L51	CONSULTANT	Who should be able to see all this in Salesforce?
L52	FINANCE MANAGER (OWEN)	Finance, and me. Sales should see the payment status but not the sync errors.
L53	CONSULTANT	Thank you. I will write this up as one page and a list of questions, so you can tell me what I've got wrong.

THREE

Questions only the client can answer

The call left 19 things open. Each has what I would suggest in the meantime, who decides, and what it holds up. The first six change the design; the rest can wait for an answer without stopping the build.

G-01 Where does the monthly billing schedule live?

Why it matters. A won deal is a single event. A 12 or 24 month contract needs somewhere that holds the start date, the term and the monthly amount, and today the contract is a PDF and the start date is in the notes. This is the biggest design decision in the project.

What I would suggest. Create a billing schedule in Salesforce when a contract is won, and let it generate the monthly drafts. Whether Xero repeating invoices could carry it instead is something to check before we commit.

Decided by **Finance manager and us** Blocks REQ-03

From L05 L06

G-02 What is a completed repair, where does the job live, and where does the final amount come from?

Why it matters. Repairs are invoiced on completion for a final amount that differs from the quote. That is a job, not a sales stage. Whether jobs stay as opportunities or become something else (for example Field Service work orders) changes the build.

What I would suggest. A completion date and a final amount entered by operations on the record, for now.

Decided by **MD and finance manager**

Blocks REQ-01, REQ-02 From L07 L10 L11

G-17 Which day is each monthly invoice dated, and which April is the first price rise?

Why it matters. The finance manager described a pile of planned maintenance invoices all at once at month end, which suggests one run rather than each contract's own day. The rise is "whatever the index says" each April, so a contract that starts in March could be uplifted a month later or could wait a year.

What I would suggest. Date each invoice on the contract's own day (the rule the checks use) and apply the first rise in the first April after the contract starts, until the client says otherwise. A single run day is simpler and the checks would follow.

Decided by **Finance manager** Blocks REQ-03

From L03 L05 L06

G-05 Which work is zero rated, exempt or reverse charge, and who decides?

Why it matters. The wrong VAT on an invoice is expensive to unpick. Reverse charge was mentioned and has not been confirmed. Reverse charge on construction work can also sit on the purchase bill rather than the sales invoice, depending on who is supplying whom, so the accountant must say which side it touches. The 5 percent reduced rate, which may apply to some work, is not mapped either, and neither is the Construction Industry Scheme: the accountant has to name them.

What I would suggest. Standard unless finance sets another treatment. Reverse charge is held for review. Please confirm with your accountant.

Decided by **Finance manager and the accountant**

Blocks REQ-05 From L16 L17

G-06 Which customers must quote a purchase order, and who receives the invoice?

Why it matters. Housing associations return invoices without a PO, so an invoice for them should be held rather than sent. The invoice goes to the managing agent, not the landlord who is the customer in Salesforce, and it is not yet clear who the contact is in Xero when the agent is billed, which affects the aged debt report.

What I would suggest. A PO number on the job and a requires-a-PO flag on the customer. A billing contact on the customer, with the paying party kept as the Xero contact until finance decides otherwise. An invoice for a customer that needs a PO is held if there is none.

Decided by **Finance manager** Blocks REQ-07

From L27

G-09 Which month do we stop typing, and who links the existing customers?

Why it matters. About 400 customers are already in Xero, around 30 of them doubles. Starting without linking them creates more doubles.

What I would suggest. Start at a month boundary after a sandbox rehearsal. Link every invoice and open deposit already in Xero for the start month first, so nothing is created twice. We produce a matching report; finance decides each double.

Decided by **Finance manager** Blocks REQ-15, REQ-18

From L41 L46 L47

G-04 Who approves invoices in the last week of the month?

Why it matters. The finance manager is away that week. Without a named deputy, drafts wait.

What I would suggest. A named deputy with approval rights in Xero.

Decided by **MD** Blocks REQ-10 From L22

G-14 When an amount changes after an invoice has gone out, who is told and what do they do?

Why it matters. The finance manager wants to be told and to deal with it in Xero. Nobody has said whether the deal in Salesforce should be locked, or what happens once the invoice has been paid.

What I would suggest. Lock the amount in Salesforce once the invoice is approved. Create a task for finance. If it has been paid, finance raises a credit note in Xero. Check in Xero whether a paid invoice can be voided without removing its payments first.

Decided by **Finance manager** Blocks REQ-12

From L30 L31 L32

G-15 Must every invoice be approved one at a time?

Why it matters. At about 600 invoices a month, approving each one individually is real work, and the finance manager said they want to see every one. The identical monthly planned maintenance invoices may not need the same attention as a one-off repair.

What I would suggest. Approve one at a time while the system is new. After the rehearsal, consider approving the identical monthly invoices as a batch and keep one-by-one approval for repairs.

Decided by **Finance manager** Blocks REQ-09

From L02 L22

G-13 What counts as quick enough for a draft to appear?

Why it matters. The managing director said "Not days. Before the end of the day, ideally." The finance manager did not say. A number is needed before it can be tested, and it should be the one the client chooses.

What I would suggest. By the end of the working day it was triggered, and by the end of the next working day for anything triggered out of hours. If the client wants it quicker, the target tightens and the check follows.

Decided by **MD** Blocks REQ-11

From L23 L24 L25

G-18 What has to be finished by the close on the third working day?

Why it matters. The books close on the third working day, and the finance manager is away in the last week of the month, when the pile of monthly invoices arrives. Nobody said whether every invoice dated in the month must be approved by the close. Xero's lock date, if finance uses one, also decides what happens to a draft dated before it.

What I would suggest. Every invoice dated in the month is approved by the close, and a warning goes to the finance manager and the deputy the working day before.

Decided by **Finance manager** Blocks REQ-20

From L03 L22

G-19 What happens when a contract ends early, renews, or is cancelled after a deposit?

Why it matters. The call covered contracts that run for 12 or 24 months and repairs with a deposit. It did not say what happens when a contract is cancelled part way, renewed, or when a repair is cancelled after the deposit invoice has been approved. Each needs a credit note, a stopped schedule or a new one, and somebody who owns the decision.

What I would suggest. Stop the schedule from the cancellation date and raise a credit note for any invoice already approved and not yet due, decided by finance each time. A renewal creates a new schedule from the old end date.

Decided by **Finance manager** Blocks REQ-03, REQ-12

From L05 L08 L39

G-20 Which Salesforce edition does the client have?

Why it matters. Some editions have no Apex and no API access without an add-on, and the call never asked. The edition decides whether the sync can be built as described or needs another route, so it is worth confirming before anything is promised.

What I would suggest. Assume an edition with API access and Apex. If it has neither, the design changes and we say so before quoting.

Decided by **Managing director** Blocks REQ-15

From L02

G-03 How is the April price rise applied, and who signs it off?

Why it matters. The uplift is 'whatever the index says' each April, so it is not a fixed number and it compounds. We need to know who decides the percentage and when.

What I would suggest. Finance sets the percentage once a year and the schedule applies it from April.

Decided by **Finance manager** Blocks REQ-03

From L06

G-07 How is each customer's payment term recorded?

Why it matters. Thirty days for most, 45 for the housing associations, 60 for one customer.

What I would suggest. A payment terms field on the customer.

Decided by **Finance manager** Blocks REQ-08

From L29

G-08 How fresh does payment status need to be, and what does a customer being behind mean?

Why it matters. Payments appear in Xero only after bank matching, so a status can be days old whatever we build. Sales also asked to see whether a customer is behind before quoting. That needs a view on the customer, not only on each invoice, and it has to decide what to do with debt from before the start month.

What I would suggest. Refresh hourly and show 'last updated' so nobody is misled. Behind means any invoice overdue, shown on the customer as a count and an amount. Debt from before the start month is loaded as one opening balance, or left out until finance decides.

Decided by **Finance manager** Blocks REQ-13

From L34

G-12 What does the rehearsal look like, given the Xero demo company resets?

Why it matters. The test needs realistic data in a place that keeps it, and a demo company is reported to reset periodically (about every 28 days).

What I would suggest. Rehearse in the sandbox against a demo company within one working week, and keep the test data as a file so it can be reloaded.

Decided by **Us** Blocks REQ-18 From L47

G-10 Is the second Xero tracking category (job type) still used?

Why it matters. Xero allows two. Region is confirmed. The second one is not used by finance today.

What I would suggest. Region only.

Decided by **Finance manager** Blocks REQ-06

From L19

G-11 The euro customer: in scope or not?

Why it matters. Handling one customer in euros means multi-currency in both systems, which is hard to undo once switched on.

What I would suggest. Out of scope. GBP only. That customer stays manual.

Decided by **MD** Blocks none (decision) From L42

FOUR

The requirements behind the one page

20 requirements, each traced to lines of the call. Where I had to assume something, it says so and points to the question that will settle it. Open a requirement for the rule and its Given, When, Then.

– **REQ-01** **Repairs are invoiced when the job is completed** MUST MY ASSUMPTION

Repairs are invoiced when the job is finished, for the final amount, not when the deal is won.

The rule. One DRAFT invoice is created in Xero for the final amount of the job, not the quote.

- **Given** a repair opportunity is Closed Won and the job is not complete **when** nothing changes **then** no invoice is created.
- **Given** the job is marked complete with a final amount **when** the sync runs **then** one DRAFT invoice for the final amount exists in Xero.

From L07 L10 L11 To confirm: G-02 Tested by TC-01

– REQ-02 Deposits on large repairs

SHOULD · MY ASSUMPTION

Large repairs can be billed as a deposit first (usually half, set per job) and a balance on completion.

The rule. The deposit is a share of the quote and is invoiced when the deal is won. The balance is the final amount less the deposit and is invoiced on completion, so the two add up to the final amount to the penny. If the final amount is below the deposit, finance is told that a credit is due.

- **Given** a repair quoted at £1,001.01 with a 50 percent deposit **when** the invoices are created **then** the deposit is £500.51 and the balance is £500.50.
- **Given** a repair quoted at £1,001.01 with a 50 percent deposit, completed at a final amount of £1,200 **when** the balance invoice is created **then** the deposit is £500.51 and the balance is £699.49, which add up to the final amount.
- **Given** a repair quoted at £1,000 with a 50 percent deposit, completed at a final amount of £400 **when** the balance is worked out **then** the balance is minus £100 and finance is told that a credit is due.

From L08 To confirm: G-02 Tested by TC-02

– REQ-03 Monthly invoices for planned maintenance

MUST · MY ASSUMPTION

Planned maintenance contracts are invoiced monthly in advance for the whole term, with the April price rise applied.

The rule. A billing schedule is created at Closed Won. One DRAFT invoice per month is created in advance, from the start date, for the term, on the contract's own day of the month (pending G-17). The annual April uplift is applied from the first April after the contract starts. Every invoice has its own code: the job number, then the billing month.

- **Given** a 12 month contract starting 31 January at 500 a month with a 3.4 percent uplift from April **when** the schedule is created **then** the dates are 31 Jan, 28 Feb, 31 Mar, 30 Apr and so on, and the amount is 517 from April.

From L05 L06 L03 To confirm: G-01, G-03, G-17 Tested by TC-03

– REQ-04 Account code by type of work

MUST · SAID ON THE CALL

The right account code is filled in for you.

The rule. Planned maintenance lines carry account 200 and repairs 210. Finance can change a code before approving.

- **Given** a planned maintenance line **when** the invoice is drafted **then** the account code is 200.

From L13 Tested by TC-04

– REQ-05 VAT treatment

MUST · MY ASSUMPTION

The right VAT is set on each invoice, and anything unusual is held for finance to decide.

The rule. Each job has a VAT treatment: Standard, Zero rated, Exempt or No VAT, mapped to the Xero tax types OUTPUT2, ZERORATEDOUTPUT, EXEMPTOUTPUT and NONE. It defaults to Standard. Anything marked reverse charge is held for review and never guessed.

- **Given** a job with no VAT treatment **when** the invoice is drafted **then** the tax type is OUTPUT2.
- **Given** a job marked reverse charge **when** the sync runs **then** no invoice is created and finance is asked.

From L16 L17 To confirm: G-05 Tested by TC-05

– REQ-06 Regional split

MUST · SAID ON THE CALL

Income is split by North and South for the board pack.

The rule. Every line carries the Region of the customer (North or South) as the Xero tracking category. A customer with no Region is held, not guessed.

- **Given** a South customer **when** the invoice is drafted **then** the Region tracking option is South.
- **Given** a customer with no Region **when** the sync runs **then** no invoice is created and the reason is logged.

From L18 L19 L20 To confirm: G-10 Tested by TC-06

– REQ-07 Purchase order number, and who is billed

MUST · SAID ON THE CALL

Invoices show the customer's PO number and go to the right person, and an invoice for a customer who needs a PO is held if there is none.

The rule. When the customer quotes a purchase order, the invoice Reference shows it, written PO HA-7781 for example, and the job number when there is no PO. A customer marked as needing a PO (the housing associations) with no PO on the job is held, not drafted, because they send the invoice straight back. The invoice goes to the billing contact when there is one, otherwise to the customer.

- **Given** a job with PO HA-7781 and job number OPP-2210 **when** the invoice is drafted **then** the Reference reads PO HA-7781.
- **Given** a housing association that needs a PO and a job with none **when** the sync runs **then** no invoice is created and finance is asked for the PO.

From L27 To confirm: G-06 Tested by TC-07

– REQ-08 Payment terms by customer

SHOULD · SAID ON THE CALL

Each customer's own payment terms are used.

The rule. The due date is the invoice date plus the customer's terms: 30 days unless the customer has 45 or 60. The invoice is dated on the day the job was completed, or on the schedule date for a monthly invoice, not on the day the sync ran.

- **Given** a customer on 45 day terms **when** an invoice is dated 1 February 2027 **then** the due date is 18 March 2027.
- **Given** a job completed on 29 January 2027, with the sync running on 1 February **when** the invoice is drafted **then** it is dated 29 January 2027 and, on 30 day terms, due on 28 February 2027.

From L29 To confirm: G-07 Tested by TC-08

– REQ-09 Finance approves every invoice

MUST · SAID ON THE CALL

Nothing goes to a customer without finance seeing it.

The rule. The sync only ever creates DRAFT invoices and never approves one. Approval happens in Xero by the finance manager.

- **Given** any invoice created by the sync **when** it appears in Xero **then** its status is DRAFT.
- **Given** the sync tries to approve an invoice **when** it runs **then** it is refused.

From L22 To confirm: G-15 Tested by TC-09, TC-10

– REQ-10 Cover when the finance manager is away

MUST · MY ASSUMPTION

Someone else can approve when the finance manager is off.

The rule. A named deputy has approval rights in Xero. If the finance manager is away and no deputy is named, finance is told before drafts pile up.

- **Given** the finance manager is away and a deputy is named **when** an invoice needs approval **then** the deputy is the approver.
- **Given** the finance manager is away and no deputy is named **when** an invoice needs approval **then** a warning is raised.

From L22 To confirm: G-04 Tested by TC-11

– REQ-11 Drafts appear by the end of the working day

SHOULD MY ASSUMPTION

A draft invoice appears by the end of the working day it was triggered, as the managing director asked.

The rule. A draft invoice appears by 17:00 on the day of the trigger, or by 17:00 on the next working day if the trigger falls outside working hours (09:00 to 17:00, Monday to Friday, bank holidays excluded). If the client wants a tighter target, the number changes and this check follows.

- **Given** a trigger at 11:00 on a Wednesday **when** the draft is created at 16:00 the same day **then** the target is met.
- **Given** a trigger at 18:00 on a Friday **when** the draft is created at 09:30 on the Monday **then** the target is met.
- **Given** a trigger at 11:00 on a Wednesday **when** the draft is created at 09:00 on the Thursday **then** the target is missed.

From L23 L24 L25 To confirm: G-13 Tested by TC-12

– REQ-12 Changes after an invoice exists

MUST MY ASSUMPTION

If the amount changes after an invoice is approved, finance is told and no second invoice is made. A draft finance has edited is never overwritten.

The rule. While an invoice is a draft, the draft is updated, unless finance has edited it in Xero: then the change goes to finance as a task and the draft is left alone. A draft deleted in Xero is reported to finance and not recreated. Once an invoice is approved it is locked, no second invoice is ever created, and a task goes to finance. The locking is per invoice, so the final amount of a repair stays editable until its balance invoice is approved. If an invoice has been paid, finance raises a credit note in Xero.

- **Given** an invoice is AUTHORISED **when** someone changes the deal amount **then** a task is created for finance and no second invoice is made.
- **Given** a deposit invoice is approved and the balance invoice does not exist yet **when** the final amount of the job is entered **then** it is accepted and the balance invoice is created from it.
- **Given** a draft that finance has edited in Xero **when** someone changes the deal amount **then** the draft is left as finance edited it and a task is created for finance.
- **Given** a draft that finance has deleted in Xero **when** someone changes the deal amount **then** finance is told and no new invoice is created.

From L30 L31 L32 To confirm: G-14 Tested by TC-13

– REQ-13 Payment status in Salesforce

MUST · MY ASSUMPTION

Sales can see whether a customer has paid, including part payments, before sending a new quote.

The rule. Salesforce shows Unpaid, Part paid, Paid or Overdue for each invoice, worked out from the amounts paid and due (Xero shows an invoice as approved and awaiting payment even when part paid). It says when it was last updated, because payments appear only after bank matching.

- **Given** an invoice of 1,200 with 600 paid and not yet due **when** the status is worked out **then** it is Part paid.

From L33 L34 L35 To confirm: G-08 Tested by TC-14

– REQ-14 Credit notes and voided invoices are visible

SHOULD · SAID ON THE CALL

Sales can see credit notes and voids against the job.

The rule. Credit notes and voids raised in Xero show against the job in Salesforce. A void on a won deal with no replacement creates a task for finance. Finance links a replacement invoice to the job; the sync never links one on its own.

- **Given** an invoice of 1,200 with a 200 credit note allocated **when** the invoice is shown **then** the net is 1,000.

From L36 L37 L38 L39 Tested by TC-15, TC-16

– REQ-15 No duplicate customers, no duplicate invoices

MUST SAID ON THE CALL

The system stops and asks rather than guess, and never bills twice.

The rule. The customer is matched by the stored Xero ID, then by an email that belongs to one customer only. If several customers match, an email is shared, or a name is only similar, the invoice is held for finance to choose. A retry never creates a second invoice: every invoice has its own key (the job number, then which invoice it is: the billing month, the deposit or the balance), kept on the Salesforce invoice record with the Xero InvoiceID once known. Xero keeps an idempotency key for six minutes from the first call, so a retry within six minutes sends the same key and Xero returns the original response. After six minutes the sync does not retry and does not search Xero and adopt a look-alike: the invoice is held for finance, who see the likely matches and decide. Only one run may touch a record at a time. If Xero cannot honour the key, the invoice is held for finance.

- **Given** a customer whose name is similar to an existing Xero customer **when** the invoice is drafted **then** it is held for finance.
- **Given** a retry after a timeout, within six minutes of the first attempt **when** the sync runs again **then** it sends the same key and no second invoice is created.
- **Given** a retry after a timeout, more than six minutes after the first attempt **when** the sync runs again **then** it does not retry, the invoice is held for finance and the likely matches are shown.
- **Given** a job whose deposit invoice is already in Xero **when** the balance invoice is created **then** it has its own key and the deposit is not taken in its place.
- **Given** a second run starts while the first is still working on the record **when** it reaches that record **then** it waits.
- **Given** one email address shared by several Salesforce accounts **when** the invoice is drafted **then** it is held for finance rather than matched.

From L32 L40 L41 To confirm: G-09 Tested by TC-17, TC-18, TC-26

– REQ-16 A list of failures and a morning email

MUST SAID ON THE CALL

Finance finds out about a failure the next morning, never at month end.

The rule. Every attempt is logged (record, direction, result, message, time). Finance has a list of failures. One email goes each morning if anything failed in the last 24 hours, and none when nothing did.

- **Given** two failures in the last 24 hours **when** it is 8am **then** one email is sent with a count of two.

From L43 L44 L45 Tested by TC-19

– REQ-17 Who sees what

MUST SAID ON THE CALL

Sales see payment status but never the technical errors.

The rule. Finance sees payment status, the log and can re-run a failed sync. Sales sees payment status only.

- **Given** a sales user **when** they open an invoice **then** they see the payment status but not the log.

From L52 Tested by TC-20

– REQ-18 A clean start

MUST MY ASSUMPTION

We pick a month, stop typing from then, and nothing is billed twice.

The rule. Nothing dated before the chosen start month is created. Every invoice already typed into Xero for the start month or later, including an open deposit, is linked to its Salesforce record first by finance, from a matching report we produce. The sync never links an invoice on its own, and nothing is created for a period that has already been invoiced. A contract already running at go-live starts its schedule from the start month, not from its original start date. Every existing Xero customer is linked to a Salesforce account first, with the doubles resolved. A full rehearsal in the sandbox against the Xero demo company passes before go-live.

- **Given** a start month of February 2027 **when** an invoice dated 28 January 2027 is considered **then** it is not created.
- **Given** a 12 month contract that started on 15 November 2026 and a start month of February 2027 **when** its schedule is loaded **then** the first draft is dated 15 February 2027 and the remaining months follow the term.
- **Given** a February 2027 invoice already typed into Xero by hand and a start month of February 2027 **when** the sync considers the same job **then** it is linked and no second invoice is created.

From L46 L47 L41 To confirm: G-09, G-12 Tested by TC-21, TC-22, TC-24

– REQ-19 Nothing goes missing

MUST SAID ON THE CALL

Nothing is lost silently: every won deal or completed job is accounted for each day, and a repair that is not finished yet is not counted as missing.

The rule. Every deal won, and every job completed, that day ends up as a draft invoice, a scheduled invoice, a held invoice with its reason, an item on the failures list, or a repair still awaiting completion. A daily count reconciles them, and anything in none of those places is listed as missing.

- **Given** 3 deals were won today and 2 of them became drafts and 1 is on the failures list **when** the daily count runs **then** all 3 are accounted for and nothing is listed as missing.
- **Given** a repair that was won today and is not finished **when** the daily count runs **then** it is shown as awaiting completion and not as missing.
- **Given** a won deal that is in none of those places **when** the daily count runs **then** it is listed as missing for the finance manager.

From L43 L45 Tested by TC-23

– REQ-20 Month end closes with every invoice approved

SHOULD MY ASSUMPTION

The books close on the third working day, so finance is warned if any of the month's invoices is still waiting for approval, or is held back in Salesforce, the working day before.

The rule. On the working day before the close (the third working day after month end), and on the close itself, every invoice dated in the month that is a draft, awaiting approval or held in Salesforce (with the reason) is listed, and finance and the named deputy are told. After the close, the same list is marked late.

- **Given** an invoice dated 15 January 2027 that is still a draft **when** it is 2 February 2027 **then** the close is 3 February 2027 and a warning names the invoice.
- **Given** all of January's invoices are approved **when** it is 2 February 2027 **then** no warning is raised.
- **Given** an invoice dated 20 January 2027 held because its PO is missing **when** it is 2 February 2027 **then** the warning lists it with the reason.

From L03 L22 To confirm: G-18 Tested by TC-25

FIVE

The test plan

Each check is written in the client's words, with the result it should give written before anything is built. 20 of the 26 checks are ones the client can run in the sandbox. The other 6, marked "We run this one", need a developer's access (to approve through the connection, cut it mid-way, change the clock or read the log), so we run them while the client watches. Every one of the 15 Must requirements has at least one check.

TC-01 A repair is invoiced when the job is done

Checks REQ-01 **You can run this**

You should see. No invoice before completion. One draft after, for the final amount, not the quote.

TC-02 The deposit and the balance add up to the penny

Checks REQ-02 **You can run this**

You should see. Deposit £500.51 on the quote and balance £699.49 on completion, which add up to the final amount of £1,200. When the job comes in below the deposit, finance is told a credit is due.

TC-03 The monthly schedule and the April price rise

Checks REQ-03 **You can run this**

You should see. Each month on the same day (or the last day of a short month), 500 until March and 517 from April. Each month is its own line, so each becomes its own invoice.

TC-04 The right account code

Checks REQ-04 **You can run this**

You should see. 200 for planned maintenance and 210 for repairs. A code finance changes is kept.

TC-05 The right VAT, and anything unusual held

Checks REQ-05 **You can run this**

You should see. 20 percent, zero rated, exempt and no VAT map to the matching Xero tax types. A job with no treatment set gets 20 percent, the rate the client said covers most work, and is flagged for finance. Reverse charge is held for finance.

TC-06 Income is split North and South

Checks REQ-06 **You can run this**

You should see. The South invoice carries the Region South. The customer with no Region is held and the reason is logged.

TC-07 The PO number and the right person

Checks REQ-07 **You can run this**

You should see. The Reference shows the PO number and nothing else, for example PO HA-7781, and the invoice goes to the billing contact, the managing agent. The invoice with no PO is held and finance is asked for it.

TC-08 Each customer's payment terms

Checks REQ-08 **You can run this**

You should see. 3 March, 18 March and 2 April 2027. The invoice for the job completed on 29 January is dated 29 January.

TC-09 The sync never approves an invoice

Checks REQ-09 **We run this one, you watch**

You should see. An attempt to approve it is refused.

TC-10 Every invoice arrives as a draft

Checks REQ-09 **You can run this**

You should see. The status is DRAFT and nothing has been sent to the customer.

TC-11 Someone can approve when the finance manager is away

Checks REQ-10 **You can run this**

You should see. The deputy approves. With no deputy, a warning is raised before drafts pile up.

TC-12 Drafts appear by the end of the working day

Checks REQ-11 **We run this one, you watch**

You should see. By 17:00 the same day. When the job is completed outside 09:00 to 17:00 on a working day, by 17:00 on the next working day.

TC-13 A changed amount never creates a second invoice

Checks REQ-12 **You can run this**

You should see. The draft is updated. The approved and paid ones are locked, no second invoice appears, and finance gets a task. For the paid one the task is to raise a credit note. A draft finance has edited is never overwritten, and a deleted draft is reported, not recreated. The final amount can still be entered after the deposit is approved, and it creates the balance.

TC-14 Payment status, including part payments

Checks REQ-13 **You can run this**

You should see. Unpaid, Part paid, Paid and Overdue are each shown correctly. Part paid does not show as Unpaid.

TC-15 Credit notes show against the job

Checks REQ-14 **You can run this**

You should see. The credit of 200 shows and the net is 1,000.

TC-16 A voided invoice is visible, and a missing replacement is chased

Checks REQ-14 **You can run this**

You should see. Both show as Void. Only the one with no replacement creates a task for finance.

TC-17 Customers are matched, or the sync asks

Checks REQ-15 **You can run this**

You should see. Linked and email matches proceed. Two matches or a similar name are held for finance. A new customer is created.

TC-18 A retry never bills twice

Checks REQ-15 **We run this one, you watch**

You should see. Within six minutes the retry carries the same key, so Xero returns the same invoice and no second one appears. After six minutes the sync does not retry and does not guess: the invoice is held for finance, who see the likely matches. A deposit is never taken for the balance, and one month is never taken for the next. A second run waits.

TC-19 Finance hears about failures the next morning

Checks REQ-16 **We run this one, you watch**

You should see. One email with a count of two. No email when nothing failed.

TC-20 Sales see payment status, not errors

Checks REQ-17 **You can run this**

You should see. Sales see the payment status only. Finance also see the log and can re-run.

TC-21 Nothing before the start month is billed

Checks REQ-18 **You can run this**

You should see. The January invoice is not created. The February one is, unless it was already typed into Xero by hand: that one is linked and never created again.

TC-22 Go live only when customers are linked and the rehearsal has passed

Checks REQ-18 **We run this one, you watch**

You should see. Ready only when none are unlinked and the rehearsal has passed.

TC-23 Nothing goes missing

Checks REQ-19 **You can run this**

You should see. Every one is accounted for. A repair that is not finished yet is not a missing invoice. Anything in none of those places is listed as missing.

TC-24 A running contract joins the schedule at the start month

Checks REQ-18 **You can run this**

You should see. The first draft is dated in February and the later months follow the term.

TC-25 Month end closes with every invoice approved

Checks REQ-20 **We run this one, you watch**

You should see. On 2 February a warning names the draft, and says the books close on 3 February. On 4 February it is marked late. When every invoice is approved, no warning is raised.

TC-26 Every invoice on a job has its own key

Checks REQ-15 **You can run this**

You should see. Four different keys, each built from the job number and which invoice it is. The Reference in Xero shows the PO only.

A rule checker, not an integration

Behind each check are the exact rules written down as small functions, so I can see whether the rules agree with the checks and with each other. It is not connected to Salesforce or Xero and it does not prove the build works. The sandbox run with the client does that. What it is good for is finding a contradiction on paper, before anything is built.

26 of 26 checks passed when this page was built. Press the button to run them again in your browser.

Check	Cases	Result
TC-01 A repair is invoiced when the job is done	4 of 4	Passes
TC-02 The deposit and the balance add up to the penny	5 of 5	Passes
TC-03 The monthly schedule and the April price rise	4 of 4	Passes
TC-04 The right account code	3 of 3	Passes
TC-05 The right VAT, and anything unusual held	6 of 6	Passes
TC-06 Income is split North and South	2 of 2	Passes
TC-07 The PO number and the right person	5 of 5	Passes
TC-08 Each customer's payment terms	5 of 5	Passes
TC-09 The sync never approves an invoice	1 of 1	Passes
TC-10 Every invoice arrives as a draft	1 of 1	Passes
TC-11 Someone can approve when the finance manager is away	3 of 3	Passes
TC-12 Drafts appear by the end of the working day	7 of 7	Passes
TC-13 A changed amount never creates a second invoice	7 of 7	Passes
TC-14 Payment status, including part payments	7 of 7	Passes
TC-15 Credit notes show against the job	2 of 2	Passes
TC-16 A voided invoice is visible, and a missing replacement is chased	2 of 2	Passes
TC-17 Customers are matched, or the sync asks	6 of 6	Passes
TC-18 A retry never bills twice	9 of 9	Passes
TC-19 Finance hears about failures the next morning	2 of 2	Passes
TC-20 Sales see payment status, not errors	5 of 5	Passes
TC-21 Nothing before the start month is billed	3 of 3	Passes
TC-22 Go live only when customers are linked and the rehearsal has passed	3 of 3	Passes
TC-23 Nothing goes missing	3 of 3	Passes
TC-24 A running contract joins the schedule at the start month	2 of 2	Passes
TC-25 Month end closes with every invoice approved	6 of 6	Passes
TC-26 Every invoice on a job has its own key	4 of 4	Passes

What the checks caught

- Writing the expected answer for the deposit case by hand first made me notice a pounds-and-pence mix-up in my own first version of the rule, before it ever ran.
- The paperwork check flagged two requirements I had marked as assumptions with no question for the client behind them: how quick is quick, and what happens when an amount changes. I added the two questions.

Checking your billing before it goes live

Step 1 We will tell you when the sandbox is ready. It is a copy of Salesforce connected to a Xero demo company. Nothing you do there touches your real accounts.

Step 2 Take the checks marked "You can run this" one at a time. Each tells you what to do and what you should see. Use realistic jobs, including an awkward one: a part payment, a credit note, a customer on a different payment term.

Step 3 Tick each check as it passes. If one does not, write down the job number and what you saw, and send us a screenshot. Do not try to fix it in Xero first.

Step 4 Your finance manager approves a handful of draft invoices exactly as on a normal day, so we can see whether it fits how they work. We run the checks marked "We run this one" with you watching.

Step 5 We rehearse a month end together on a copy of last month. Only when that passes do we choose the month to stop typing and go live.

If something looks wrong

That is what this stage is for. Tell us what you expected and what you saw. If you are not sure whether it is wrong, send it anyway.

SEVEN

Two things I would raise with you, not with the client yet

Switch on Xero's own reminders first. The finance manager spends Monday mornings chasing by hand and did not know Xero could do it. Xero has built-in invoice reminders (reported to fire only for invoices marked as sent), so before anything is built for chasing, it is worth switching them on and seeing what is left. [S11]

Repairs look like jobs, not deals. The hardest part of this project is that a repair is invoiced on completion for a final amount, which is a job rather than a sales stage. If the client's work grows, Field Service might suit them. That is a conversation for you and the client, not a suggestion I would make on a first call.

APPENDIX

The review, and the kit

The part of the work that decides whether a requirement is any good is the review. This shows a first draft of the requirements from the same call next to the set I would send, and the kit that runs the checks.

The working method in the kit: four stages, and where a person stops the line

1 **Draft the requirements from the transcript.** An assistant drafts. A person checks every requirement against the lines of the call and removes anything the client did not say.

2 **List what the call left open.** The assistant proposes questions. A person decides which matter and writes the suggestion for each.

3 **Write the checks in the client's words.** The assistant drafts the steps. A person writes the expected result by hand, from the rules in plain words, before anything runs.

4 **Run the paperwork check and the rule checker.** A command reads the case, flags loose words, unsourced requirements and untested ones, runs every check, and stops if anything fails. Nothing goes to the client until it passes and a person has read it.

A real AI first draft, and what I changed

A first draft of the requirements from this call, from an AI assistant given a plain instruction and no hints, kept untouched so you can read it, including its own assumptions (it calls the finance manager "she") and one aside, about an office move, from an earlier version of the call that I have since cut: the first draft (Markdown).

Measure	AI first draft	Reviewed set
Requirements	28	20
Marked Must	21 of 28	15 of 20
Acceptance criteria written with a placeholder such as [monthly amount]	11 of 60	none of 45; 107 concrete cases with real figures run in the checker
Questions for the client	12	19, each with a suggestion and a decider
Points where the draft was closer to the call than my first pass	3	put back: the missing-PO hold, the month-end close, the end of the working day

What the draft did well

- It stayed on the transcript. Almost every requirement carries an "unclear or assumption" note, and it said that the finance manager and Owen look like one person but the call does not say so. I now assume they are one person, say so on the page, and ask the client to confirm.
- It left the tangents (vans, the office move) out and put the euro customer in a "discussed but not carried forward" list.
- It caught the start date being in the opportunity notes, the managing director's "nothing goes missing" test, how a running contract joins at go-live, and whether 600 invoices really need approving one at a time. I took the last three.
- It was closer to the call than my first pass on three points. It made a missing purchase order for a housing association a Must, because the client said they send the invoice straight back, and it kept the third-working-day close. I had dropped both, and have put them back (REQ-07 and REQ-20). Its key for a monthly invoice, one per billing month, was also the right size.

What I changed, and why

- **Priorities.** It marked 21 of 28 as Must, and said nobody had ranked them. I kept Must for what the client said must not fail (approval, no double billing, VAT, the failures list) and made timing and deposits Should.
- **Scope.** It turned two things nobody asked for into requirements: a job type tracking category (it said so itself) and automatic overdue reminders, which the managing director only said would be "worth something". I moved reminders out, to the section above.
- **Placeholders.** 11 of its 60 acceptance criteria say "[monthly amount]" or similar, which cannot be run. Mine use real figures, and real figures forced rules the draft never reached: a deposit of 1,001.01 at half is 500.51 and 500.50, a contract starting on the 31st has no 31st in February, and the April rise compounds.
- **Xero detail.** It sensibly held the non-standard VAT cases for the accountant, but never got as far as the Xero tax types, where zero rated, exempt and no VAT are three different things. It asked for part paid to show, but not why that has to be worked out from the amounts: Xero shows an invoice as approved and awaiting payment even when part of it has been paid.
- **Retries.** It stopped a second invoice for the same month, but not a retry after a timeout when Xero already holds the invoice. Mine gives every invoice its own key (the job, then the month, the deposit or the balance), keeps it on the Salesforce invoice record and sends it as the idempotency key. Xero keeps a key for only six minutes, so a retry inside that window is the same request, and after it the invoice is held for finance with the likely matches shown, because repeating an expired key would create a duplicate. The key stays out of the Reference, which finance can edit and housing association payables read.
- **"Quick".** It took the managing director's "before the end of the day, ideally" as a soft target. I made it something a check can fail without changing what the managing director asked for: a draft by the end of the working day, and a question on whether something tighter is meant.

The kit

The whole case is a handful of plain files you can read: the call, the requirements, the questions and the checks as data, the rule checker, the paperwork check and one command that runs them all. It stops with a failure if anything is loose, untraced or untested. Download the kit. To run it you need Node and one line: `node check.mjs`.

METHOD AND SOURCES

What is invented, what is public

Invented. The client, the people, the call and every figure in the case. Nothing comes from a real company, and the rule checker is not connected to any system.

Public. Only the points below, each with its source.

1. The advert for the Junior Consultant, Salesforce and AI role, on Indeed. The advert (https://uk.indeed.com/viewjob?jk=8397dcdb7cab434c)

2. Xero invoice statuses: approved and awaiting payment or partly paid, paid, voided, draft, awaiting approval. The UK tax types used in the mapping: 20 percent VAT on income, 5 percent, zero rated, exempt and no VAT. Xero tax types (https://developer.xero.com/documentation/api/accounting/types)
3. Xero invoice fields used in the mapping: a unique invoice number for receivable invoices (generated by Xero when left blank), a free-text Reference, account code, tax type and tracking on each line, and amounts paid and due. Xero invoices (https://developer.xero.com/documentation/api/accounting/invoices)
4. Xero Developer, idempotent requests: an Idempotency-Key header on POST, PUT and PATCH, keys kept for six minutes from the first call, the same key on a different request returns an error, and a key repeated after it has expired is processed as a new request. Xero's idempotency guide (https://developer.xero.com/documentation/guides/idempotent-requests/idempotency/)
5. Xero's demo company is reported to reset about every 28 days. This comes from two integration partners' guides, not from Xero's own help pages, so confirm it before relying on it. Routable's sandbox guide (https://developers.routable.com/docs/xero-sandbox) and ApprovalMax's guide (https://support.approvalmax.com/en/articles/413805-how-can-i-try-approvalmax-with-the-xero-demo-company)
6. Xero invoice reminders fire only for invoices marked as sent. This is reported by customers on Xero's own ideas forum, not from Xero's help pages, so confirm it before relying on it. Xero ideas forum thread (https://productideas.xero.com/forums/967115-invoices-quotes/suggestions/45215710-invoices-automatically-mark-invoices-from-wfm-as)

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